

# SERGE GAINSBOURG

The Genius of Provocation



1969. Denounced by the  
Vatican. Banned by the BBC.  
Withdrawn by its own  
record label.



The Song That Was Banned Everywhere

# Je t'aime... moi non plus

Written in one night, in 1967, for Brigitte Bardot — who  
begged him never to release it.

The first foreign-language single  
ever to reach number one in  
Britain.

**A scandal that sells is not an accident. For Serge  
Gainsbourg it was a method.**

# Serge Gainsbourg — A Journey Through Provocation



## *Introduction to the Subject and Guiding Thread*

### **A failed painter.**

Lucien Ginsburg wanted to be a painter and believed he had no genius for it. He burned his canvases and turned to the art he despised: popular song.

### **A face he hated.**

The ears, the nose, the heavy eyes. He called himself ugly all his life — and built an aesthetic, then a persona, then a monument out of that wound.

### **The thread.**

Each scandal was staged, timed and exploited. The craft underneath was immaculate.

**He turned his fractures into a signature — and his signature into a brand.**

PART 1

# THE MAN WHO HID

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*A Yellow Star, a Painter's Failure, and a Pianist  
in the Shadows*



# The Four Founding Dates

The arc of a life in four milestones.



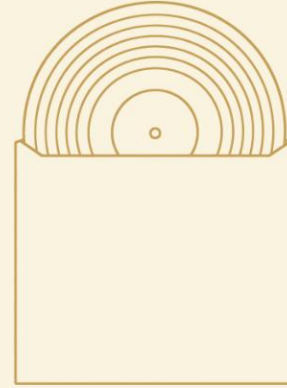
**1928**

Lucien Ginsburg is born in Paris, 2 April, to Russian-Jewish immigrants.



**1958**

Le Poinçonneur des Lilas. A first album and a new name: Serge Gainsbourg.



**1969**

Je t'aime... moi non plus with Jane Birkin. The worldwide scandal.



**1991**

Dies 2 March, rue de Verneuil. Mitterrand: "our Baudelaire, our Apollinaire."

**From the yellow star to the national funeral — and the wall that fans still cover in writing.**

# The Yellow Star

*A Childhood Under the Occupation*

## **Joseph and Olga Ginsburg.**

Fled the Russian Civil War to Paris. The father plays piano in bars and casinos, and drills his twins — Lucien and Liliane — in Chopin and scales.

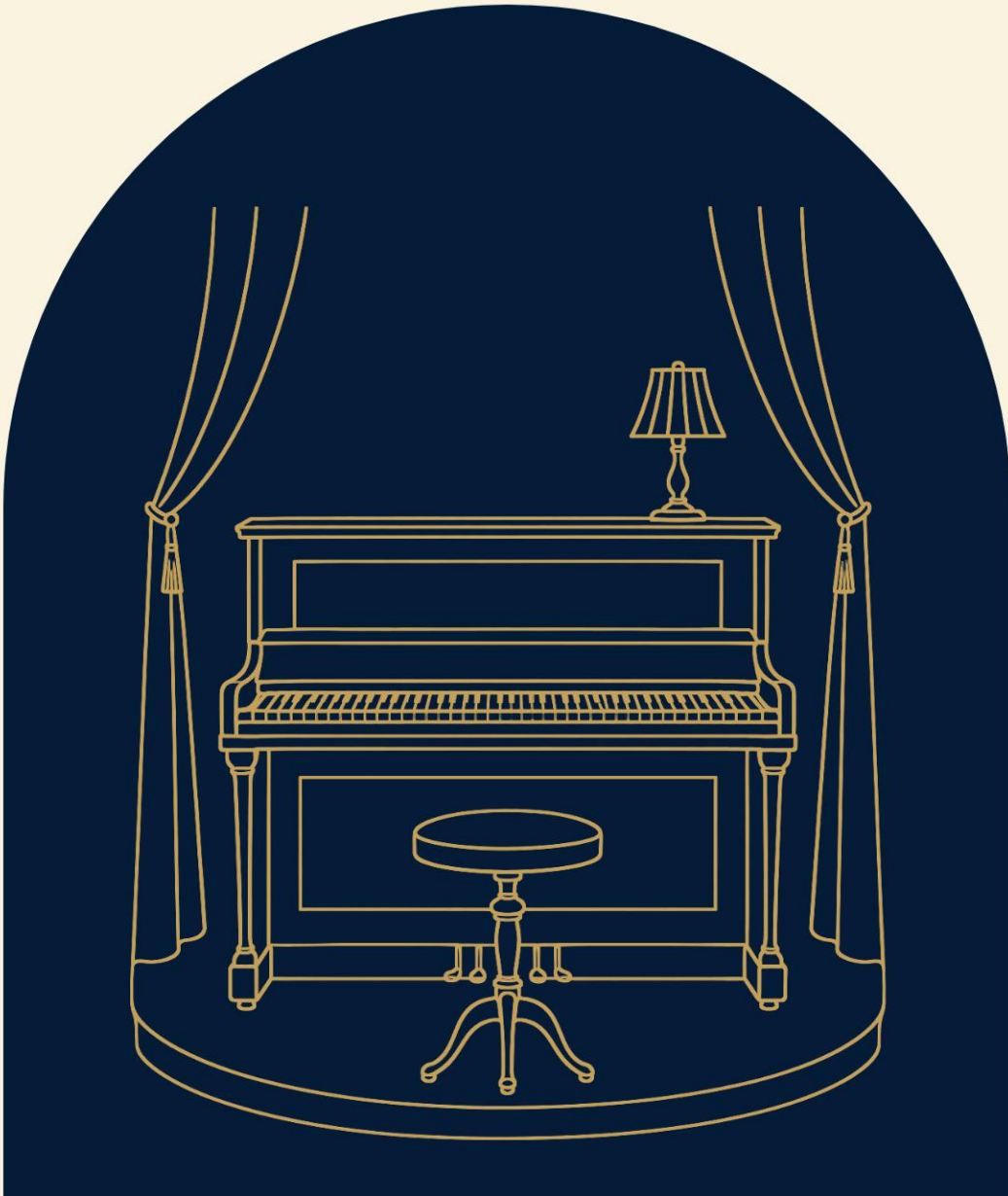
## **1942.**

The boy is fourteen when he is made to wear the yellow star. He later says he wore it like a sheriff's badge.

## **What it leaves.**

A lifelong obsession with his own appearance, a fascination with uniforms and transgression — and the 1975 album *Rock Around the Bunker*, which turns the trauma into cabaret.

**He never spoke of the war with pathos. He wrote it into songs that made people uncomfortable.**



# The Failed Painter

## Académie Montmartre

He studies painting, meets Dalí, and holds painting above every other art.

## Around thirty

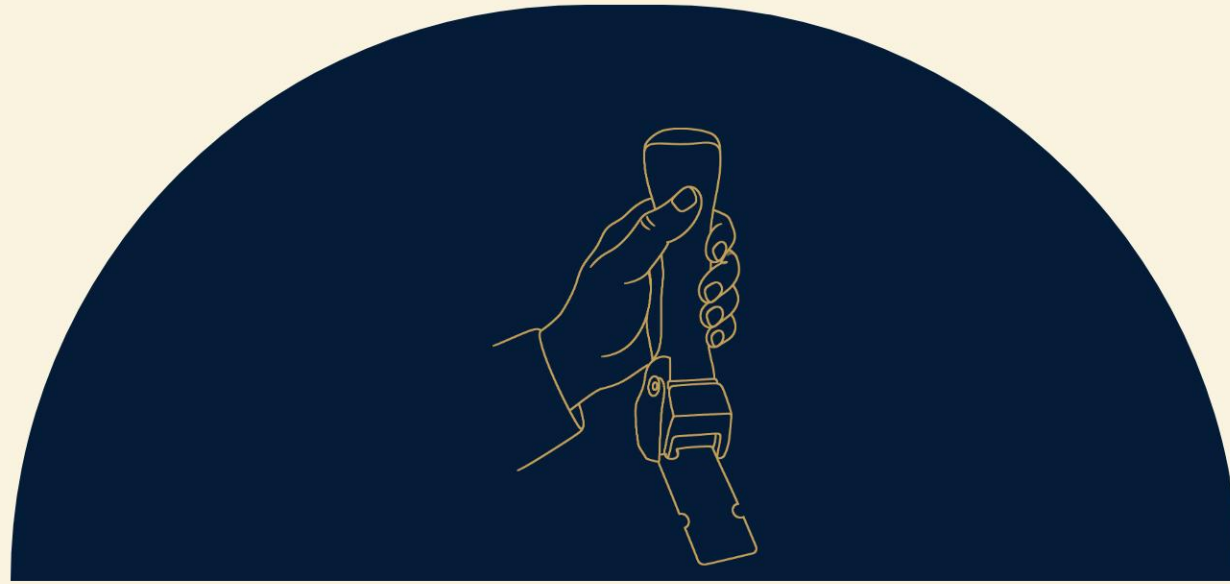
He decides he will never be a great painter and burns the canvases.

# PAINTER

## “Song is a minor art”

The verdict he repeated for the rest of his life — about the art he was good at.

**The minor art became his masterpiece. He never forgave it.**



## 1958: Le Poinçonneur des Lilas

**A ticket-puncher in the Métro.** A man who makes holes all day and dreams of one last hole — in his own head.

**The new name.** Lucien becomes Serge — Russian, severe — and Ginsburg becomes Gainsbourg, after the English painter Gainsborough.

**Critics love it. The public does not.** Too literary, too cold, too ugly for television.

**He arrived as an author, not a star. The star would have to be manufactured.**

# Writing for Others

*Gréco, Gall, and the Scandal of the Lollipops*



**The first scandal was built on someone else's innocence. The pattern was set.**

PART 2

# THE ART OF SCANDAL

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*Bardot, Birkin, Melody Nelson and a Reggae  
Marseillaise*





## 1967–1968: Bardot, then Birkin

*Two Women, One Song, and a Tape in a Drawer*

**Bardot.** A disastrous first date, then a demand: the most beautiful love song he can imagine. In one night he writes Bonnie and Clyde and Je t'aime...

**Birkin.** 1968, on the set of Slogan: a twenty-one-year-old English actress with a wicker basket and a gap-toothed smile.

**The couple.** For twelve years they are the most photographed couple in France. She is his muse, his voice and, as he would say, his masterpiece.

**The Bardot version is a duet of equals. The Birkin version is a scandal. He released the scandal.**

# 1971: Histoire de Melody Nelson

*The Concept Album Nobody Bought*

## **Twenty-eight minutes.**

A man in a Rolls-Royce knocks a red-haired girl off her bicycle.



## **A commercial failure.**

Fewer than twenty thousand copies sold at the time.

**The record that failed is the one the musicians still study.**



## 1979: Aux armes et cætera

*A Reggae Marseillaise, Paratroopers, and a Manuscript*

**Kingston, Jamaica.** Recorded with Sly and Robbie and Bob Marley's backing singers. **The reaction.** Death threats. **The last word.** In 1981 he buys Rouget de Lisle's original manuscript at auction — and points out that the refrain is written “aux armes et cætera.”

He insulted the anthem, then proved he knew it better than his accusers. That is the Gainsbourg move.

# Gainsbarre

*The Double, the Banknote, and the Television Years*



**Gainsbourg**

Composer and arranger. Melody Nelson, the Bardot and Birkin songs, the craft.



**Gainsbarre**

Unshaven, drunk, on television. Burns a 500-franc note in 1984, propositions Whitney Houston in 1986.

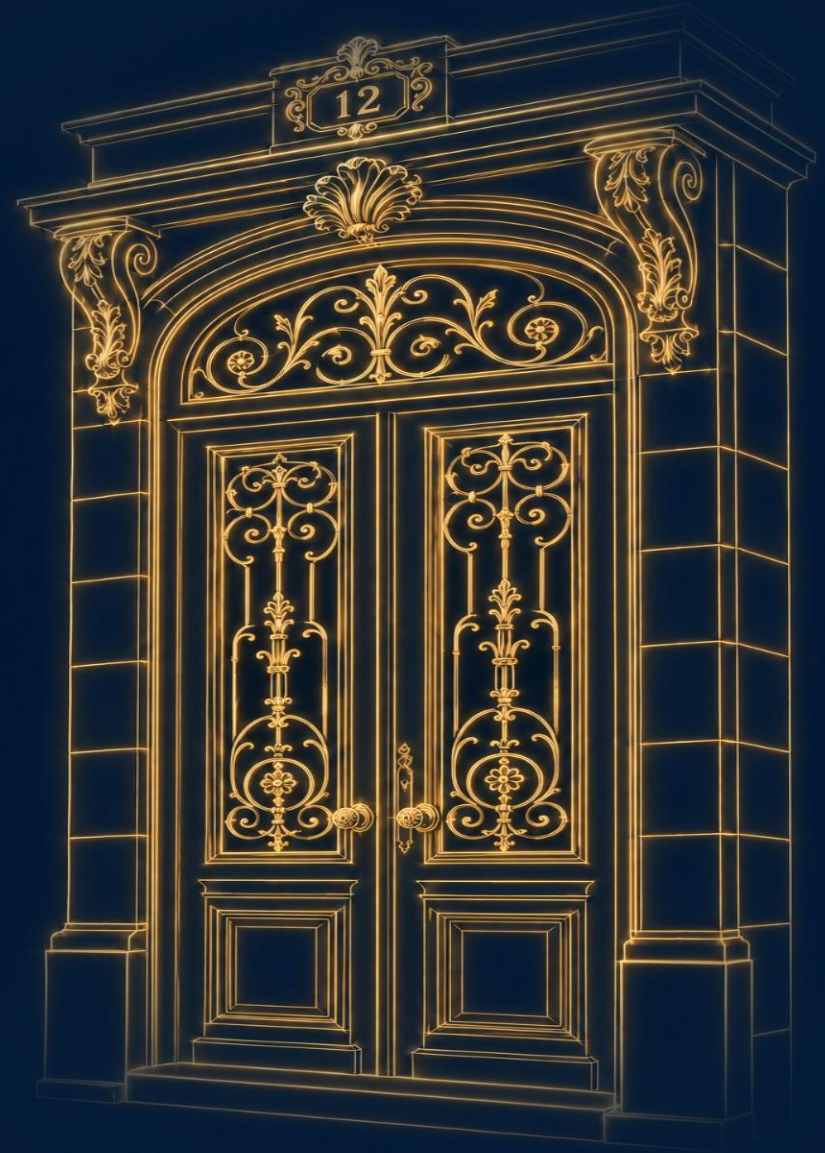
**The character paid the bills and devoured the author.**

PART 3

# THE MYTH AND THE SHADOW

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*Lemon Incest, the Wall on Rue de Verneuil, and  
the Fabrication of a Legend*





## **The Shadow: Lemon Incest, 1984**

**A duet with his daughter.** Charlotte Gainsbourg is twelve.

**The defence.** He insisted the song was about a love that is never consummated.

**What we do with it.** Neither erase it nor excuse it.

**The provocateur knew exactly where the line was. That is why he crossed it.**



### **5 bis, rue de Verneuil**

The house he kept as a black museum of himself — untouched since 1991, opened to the public in 2023.



### **The Catalogue**

Some five hundred songs, for Gréco, Adjani, Deneuve, Hardy, Birkin, Bardot, Vanessa Paradis.



### **The Posthumous Design**

He staged his own legend — the Gitanes, the Repetto shoes, the refusal to be liked — so that death would only confirm it.

**He wrote the myth himself, then let France finish the sentence.**

## 2 March 1991

*A Death, a President, and a Cemetery*

### **Rue de Verneuil.**

A fifth heart attack, at sixty-two. Fans gather at the door within hours and begin to write on the wall.

### **The State speaks.**

President Mitterrand: "He was our Baudelaire, our Apollinaire.

### **The afterlife.**

Charlotte, Jane, Lulu; the house; the biopic; the samples. The man who said song was a minor art is now taught as literature.

**The ugliest man in French song became its most beautiful legend — on purpose.**



# Sixty-Two Years in One Hour

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A child who hid under the yellow star made hiding, and revealing, his art.

A painter who failed gave popular song the discipline of composition.

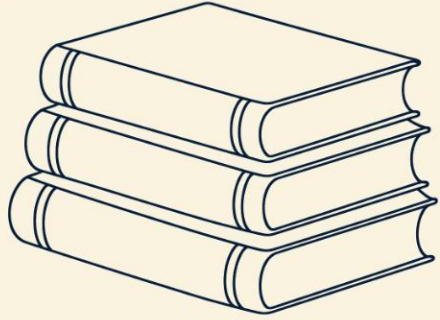
A face he hated became the most recognisable silhouette in France.

And every scandal was a stage — including the ones we cannot forgive.



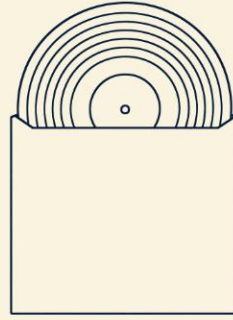
**He asked to be remembered for the craft. He made sure we would remember the scandals too.**

# Sources & Further Reading



## Reading

Gilles Verlant, Gainsbourg (biography) · Sylvie Simmons, Serge Gainsbourg: A Fistful of Gitanes · Jane Birkin, Munkie Diaries · Maison Gainsbourg (museum catalogue, 2023).



## Listening, in Order

Du chant à la une! (1958) · Histoire de Melody Nelson (1971) · L'Homme à tête de chou (1976) · Aux armes et cætera (1979) · Love on the Beat (1984).



## Watching

Gainsbourg (Vie héroïque), Joann Sfar (2010) · Slogan, Pierre Grimblat (1969) · The 1980 Strasbourg Marseillaise footage · Jane B. par Agnès V. (1988).